The Basic Text Uncut: Evolution of the Editions

by

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Ph.D., M.B.A.
2024

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The Basic Text started with a request going out to all the known Home Groups in the world. The request was for every member of NA to provide input for the book. One of the goals was to capture the spirit of recovery and the program in a book. This included contributing input as one would contribute input when sharing at a meeting; by sharing our experience with recovery, as honestly as we can. An addict who took responsibility for the effort, with the World Service Office's (WSO) help by providing Home Group addresses, sent this request out in 1978 to every registered Home Group in the world (1).

Throughout the information gathering effort, over 800 pieces of content came into the WSO ranging from a sentence hand written on a napkin, to later during the third World Literature Conference (WLC), an entire chapter on the traditions (7). During the first three WLC conferences, held October 1979 to February 1981, the material was compiled into a draft version of the basic text. The third conference lasted 10 days, included 70 addicts who expended in excess of 4,500 people hours working to produce the Rough Draft version of the basic text (2). The end results became known as The Grey Form (or Grey Book) (3). In February 1981, the Grey Book, or final draft of the basic text, was mailed to every known Home Group in the world, asking for feedback. Each sentence in the entire book was numbered, allowing the ability for every member of an NA Home Group to provide their input on an exact sentence located anywhere in the book.

Over the next several months feedback from the fellowship started coming into the WLC. The next three WLC conferences, which occurred throughout 1981, included taking all the input from the fellowship and incorporating it into the Approval Draft of the basic text by means of additions, deletions, updates, and edits (2). Once all the input from the fellowship was incorporated into the draft version of the basic text, it was ready for final approval from the fellowship. This final version of the basic text draft was known as The Approval Form (or Slick Book). In November of 1981, the Approval Form was sent out to the entire fellowship to be voted on, via group conscience, as to Accept or Not (4). In an effort to reduce the cost of printing and mailing, the personal stories were excluded from the mailing. A printing and shipping fee of around eleven dollars was requested as a donation.

The approval form was accepted by the entire fellowship of NA, every Home Group in the world had the opportunity to participate in the creation, changing, and acceptance of the Basic Text. At the World Service Conference (WSC) on Saturday, May 7, 1982 the WLC chair made a motion to accept the basic text Approval Form as the 1st edition of our Narcotics Anonymous Book known as The Basic Text. The

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motion passed. (5) The Approval Form was handed over to the World Service Office (WSO) for printing in May 1982 (5) (6).

The WSO ability to print the Basic Text took well over a year which seems absurd to us now since we can upload a PDF or Word document to an on-line printing company and have a book printed the same day (7). During this year a few members of the Board Of Trustee's (BOT) took it upon themselves to change the text in the fourth and ninth traditions by deleting sentences the BOT did not agree with (8). This is known as the Basic Text 1st Edition (9). This also became the beginning of what is known inside NA as the Traditions Wars (10).

The specific unauthorized deletions from the basic text are the following five sentences (8):

Tradition Four: in reference to anything other than an NA group, such as NAWS/WSO/Zonal/Region/Area/Conventions/Committees/etc:

a) "The answer is that these things are not N.A."
b) "All else in not N.A."
c) "Whether we choose to utilize these services is up to the group."

Tradition Nine: in reference to service bodies in Narcotics Anonymous, including NAWS/WSO/Zonal/Region/Area/Conventions/Committees/etc:

d) "None of them has the power to rule, censor, decide or dictate."
e) "They exist solely to serve the fellowship, but they are not part of Narcotics Anonymous."

Per the second WLC chairperson, "The crazy thing is a service body [WSO] censored our book by removing the line that said they couldn't censor our book!" (79).

There are many conflicting stories surrounded the first edition of the basic text, and exactly who is responsible for changing the Fellowship approved book by altering the fourth and ninth tradition. The only piece of documentation that exists is a hand written letter from the BOT Chairman to an addict taking responsibly for participating in altering the book in 1982 (8).

The situation was so troubling to our trusted servants, that the WLC chairperson sent a letter to the WSO revoking the WSO rights to the copyright of the book (15). In 1983, the World Service Board (WSB)

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chairperson sent out a letter to the fellowship taking responsibility for making unauthorized changes to the Basic Text because the WSB and WSO considered the original writings to contain "inaccuracies" (14). Many years later the WSO produced another memo, *A Brief History of the Basic Text,* stating that the WSO/WSB made the decision to remove these lines which state that the service structure should not be considered part of NA (11).

The few board members responsible for this deceit is a long story for another essay (8) (12) (13) (14). The fact is the fellowships written text was changed without Fellowship approval. The sad part is that every addict had a chance to provide feedback recommending changes to the Grey Book (3). If addicts at the world service office, or anyone else in the world, wanted certain sentences deleted – they could have made the request by providing feedback like every other addict and Home Group did using the Grey Book *Review Input Form* (3). Perhaps this happened and the fellowship voted down their changes. Perhaps it didn't and that is why a few members at the world level took it upon themselves to change the book. Whatever the reasons, four people from the WSB/WSO/BOT took it upon themselves to delete content from the fourth and ninth traditions text (59) (60); then send the altered unauthorized version to print the Basic Text 1st Edition.

The fellowship was pissed! (15) (16) To quote the chairperson of the WSO, "you would of thought we killed someone by the reaction we received from the fellowship" (19). The World Literature Committee was so disappointed by the WSO failure to fulfill their commitment and attempted deceit that the WLC revoked the WSO copyright and permission to print the Basic Text (72) (73). The fellowship demanded that their book was restored to how it was written and approved by the fellowship (24). The WSO simply ignored the WSC letter revoking their rights to the book. With use of the WSO lawyers, the 2nd WSC Literature Chairperson was unfairly scapegoated (18). Then the WSO proceeded to print the correct version (17). The restored book is the Basic Text 2nd Edition (20).

Some powers at the WSO still felt threatened by the clear language in the fourth and ninth traditions which plainly identified the groups of Narcotics Anonymous have the power in the NA service structure, and that the NA service structure is not part of NA, but a service structure accountable to NA (21). The WSO performed a manipulation of excepted voting procedures at the WSC and forced a quick vote on changing the fourth and ninth traditions text back to the way that WSO had had it in the first edition, deleting the sentences in question from the four and ninth tradition text (80). The basis used for this vote was a letter sent from a group in Nebraska.

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The Nebraska group did not want or ask for a vote, but only had "*some questions regarding the 12 Traditions of N.A. that we would like to have answered*" (80). The vote went back to the groups in the fellowship requiring a 60 day turnaround. Such a procedure did not exist in our service structure (7). Which is why many in NA believe this vote is invalid, and believe it was a calculated manipulative move by the WSO exploiting the system. During the 60 days, the WSO sent out a memo to all Home Groups on the vote with opposing viewpoints which appears to strongly skew the view to the WSO desired outcome (25).

The unprecedented vote did occur with many Home Groups not having the ability (this was pre-Internet) nor sufficient time to response in such a quick fashion. Still, according to WSO, when the mail-in votes were counted by the WSO, the fellowship voted to change the fourth and ninth tradition back to what WSO wanted. Interestingly though, the mail-in votes have never been seen by anyone other than two members of the WSO (22). When asked to see the mailed in ballots, the WSO stated "the ballets have been kept and are on file in a fire proof cabinet at the WSO" (22) (62) (64). Later, when pressed to produce the votes, the WSO said they cannot find the votes and they appear to have been lost (42) (83). The WSO once again removed the wording in the text of tradition 4 and 9, and began printing the Basic Text 3rd Edition (23). Many members of the fellowship were outraged by this move, including the Philadelphia Area (53).

In 1985, the world service board of trustees, without any notice to the fellowship, formed a closed literature committee off limits to fellowship input to make revisions to the Little White Book (21). These revisions were to eliminate references to "Sobriety", eliminate implied endorsements of Alcoholics Anonymous, change "recovered" to "recovering", and eliminate references to specific drug use (26). The final output was the little white book, newly revised (54). This was offered for conference approval only, with no review and input process at the WSC 1986 (27). The conference approved the White Book revisions. Another motion was passed to incorporate the little white book changes into the Basic Text 3rd Edition; thus producing the Basic Text 3rd Edition Revised (28).

The Basic Text 3rd Edition Revised ends the open-participation of the fellowship (Home Groups) in the creation, editing, and approval of literature. After this point, all literature is created with paid special workers. The fellowship may submit stories or others pieces of information, but this is all edited by paid professionals (57). Here is an excerpt from a WSO professionally paid special worker's resume who worked at the WSO from 1987-1996 (57):

Just for Today: Daily Meditations for Recovering Addicts (1992). I wrote a little over a quarter of the entries myself and was editorial supervisor for the 3 other writers on the project.

It Works: How and Why (1993). After watching four unsuccessful attempts over a period of 10 years to develop a book on NA's Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions, I created an editorial process that produced copy quickly and inexpensively and that the organization could feel comfortable with. I wrote more than a quarter of the text myself, editing the rest.

Many old timers believe the removal of Home Groups participating in literature creation reduced the power of recovery for addicts (69). Home Groups were a place to have input in the review and creation of NA literature; to participate in Narcotics Anonymous as a voice having input into the fellowship (21) (58). The elimination of this process has reduced the feeling of connectedness to the fellowship. According to the first editor of NA Way magazine and member of NA (83), violations of the seventh tradition also include all contributions to NA, not only money, but talents too as "*we all have our creativity, and [are] being denied the opportunity to help develop and share our message not only limits recovery, but violates Tradition 7*." (81)

Without informing the fellowship, the WSO made a deal with Hazelton Foundation, the largest supplier of treatment related material to sell the Basic Text (29). However, Hazelton did not like the "addict-to-addict" context that addicts can relate to, and wanted the book edited to their perception of a professional standard, including their accommodations of the treatment industry (21). Basically, Hazelton wanted to water down the message, put a cut on addicts' recovery, and use the book in treatment centers.

At the next world service conference the closed world literature committee and the world service office asked the fellowship for permission to edit the basic text once again, making grammatical changes only, without distorting the meaning (30). A non-addict professional editor was hired to edit our text; thus producing the Basic Text 4th Edition (31).

In 1987 the fourth edition was introduced to the fellowship without fellowship approval or authorization (7) (21). Once again, the fellowship was pissed! Many members, areas, and regions of NA wrote letters to the BOT; such as the Buckeye, and the Michigan regions (67) (68). The fellowship was angry because

the fourth edition *"was not light editing, but a massive rewrite of the Basic Text"* (7). There were hundreds of minor changes, nearly thirty lines completely deleted, and perhaps more importantly the removal and changes to many conceptual ideas in which addicts were communicating with each other through the basic text (32) (7). The addict-to-addict language was being removed. The therapeutic value of one addict helping another was being removed. The fellowship demanded that the Basic Text be returned to its original context; or restored to the last fellowship approved version which is the 3rd Edition Revised (33) (34) (35).

The non-addict executive director of the World Service Office, Bob Stone, said that we could not go back to the third edition revised because the WSO had signed contracts with an outside enterprise, the Hazelton Foundation, accepted funds and thousands of copies had been distributed to the Hazelton Foundation already (21) (66). Bob suggested a compromise, that the thirty missing lines were reinserted (7). So the professional editor combined some of the third edition revised with the fourth edition. The professional editor also provided Hazelton with final say in the edits, not the fellowship, and produced the Basic Text 5th Edition (36).

The fifth edition of the basic text was a huge disappointment. It was the basic text with a huge cut on it. The purity of the NA message was watered down to satisfied an outside enterprise (Hazelton) so they could have a treatment center friendly version of the basic text (55).

Many addicts were extremely disappointed by WSO's refusal to honor its commitment and return the basic text to the addict-to-addict language and not the treatment center friendly version. That combined with WSO unwillingness to lower the cost of a basic text to Home Groups so H&I could provide more literature to those without funds in need. Some Home Groups took it upon themselves to restore the basic text to last fellowship Home Group approved version without the WSO manipulation of the fourth and ninth tradition text removal; this resulted in a Basic Text version known as the Baby Blue (38). The Baby Blue version of the basic text is simply the Basic Text 3rd Edition Revised with the fourth and ninth tradition text deletions added back in. Another perspective is the Baby Blue is the Basic Text 2nd Edition with the 1986 Little White Book changes bundled into one book (20) (71). Therefore, the Baby Blues contains the first 10 chapters of the Basic Text without the stories, which is the Narcotics Anonymous program. Most copies are printed without staples so they can be distributed in prisons, jails, hospitals, and institutions. Baby Blues are produced by NA Home Groups for about a dollar a copy and are always given away for free to the addict still suffering who is seeking recovery.

The Baby Blue is generally accepted as the last Basic Text version that was Fellowship approved. Some of the members responsible for the creation and free distribution of the Baby Blues suffered dearly (42). Grateful Dave was sued by WSO for his involvement of printing and distributing the Baby Blues. Grateful Dave actually won the lawsuit, but died of AIDS shortly afterwards in 1991. NAWS is currently in contempt of court for not upholding their end of the lawsuit. The contempt of court case includes the WSO failure to provide the Home Groups with:

1) a document with all changes to the Basic Text,
2) a copy of the 3rd Edition Revised, and
3) a vote allowing all the Home Groups to select which Basic Text (1 – 5) that the Fellowship wants to use as the official version.

Prior to 1986, all Narcotics Anonymous literature was created by addicts as a *Labor Of Love*. This was reaffirmed by the judge overseeing the case. Therefore, addicts are able to print and freely distribute any NA literature developed prior to 1986, developed as a *Labor of Love* – which means there was no payment to anyone for authoring, including editors. This appears to be why Home Groups are able to print and give away Baby Blues freely and NAWS is not suing anyone. There is a huge amount of information available on Grateful Dave vs. WSO available online (40), including a summary on the events which took place (50). Big Lou was also involved in the printing and free distribution of Baby Blues in Florida. Tragically, Big Lou was called out in the middle of the Saturday night speaker at the World Convention in 1991 by a WSO trustee (41). Threatened and abandon by misinformed members of NA, Big Lou died of an overdose a few years later. Many, including this author, feel that Bob Berg of the WSO, is personally responsible for killing Big Lou; or at a minimum for setting up an environment of disunity, hatred, abandonment, feeling unloved and rejection from the fellowship, making recovery for Big Lou extremely difficult if not impossible in NA. Bill A., who is still alive from the Philadelphia Area, was also involved with the Baby Blues, offering them free to addicts. Bill A., Grateful Dave, and Big Lou all worked together. WSO also sent letters directly to seven churches, in Bill A and Grateful Dave's area, where WSO knew that the Baby Blue meetings were being held and inform the churches that the people holding these meetings are not NA members and the meetings are not NA meetings (69). Bill is still getting Baby Blues printed for a dollar twenty a copy, giving them away for free, and has recorded a 5-series podcast covering a detailed history of the Baby Blue (74).

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The WSO incorporated a campaign to stop Home Groups from printing and freely distributing the Baby Blue. WSO sent a letter to the fellowship (43) (44) (63), hired a law firm (46), spent over a hundred thousand dollars (7) (21), and had their lawyers send Cease and Desist letters (47) to addicts all over the world, all without gaining or even asking for Fellowship approval or permission. Note that Cease and Desist letters can only come from a court of law, not a lawyer, this was only a fear campaign waged on the fellowship by the WSO lawyers. The WSO perspective is the free distribution of the Baby Blue must be stopped to save the integrity of the Basic Text (45). Another perspective is that WSO funds are generated by book sales. And the distribution of free Basic Texts (Baby Blue) placed a huge financial burden on WSO by a reduction in funds received from the sale of literature. Grateful Dave himself is responsible for the distribution of over 9000 Baby Blues. Looking at the math, NAWS sells a Basic Text for $ 11.95, which cost them $ 2.05 to produce, generating a $ 9.90 profit per book (82). $ 9.90 per book sale at 9,000 book totals $ 89,100 potentially lost to WSO just for Grateful Dave's efforts. This does not include the thousands of books Big Lou was able to print that did not contain staples allowing them to be taking to H&I meetings and given out freely in jails and prisons to suffering addicts. The WSO did send out an apology letter to the fellowship for the Cease and Desist letter (48). Mostly due to the tremendous feedback from fellowship members in which the WSO betrayed NA membership anonymity by providing members first and last names, addresses, and phone numbers to outside enterprises including the World Service Office lawyers (49).



The fifth edition remained for five years, then NA World Services (NAWS) informed the fellowship that there was a significant "flow funds" problem, and recommended that a new basic text was printed

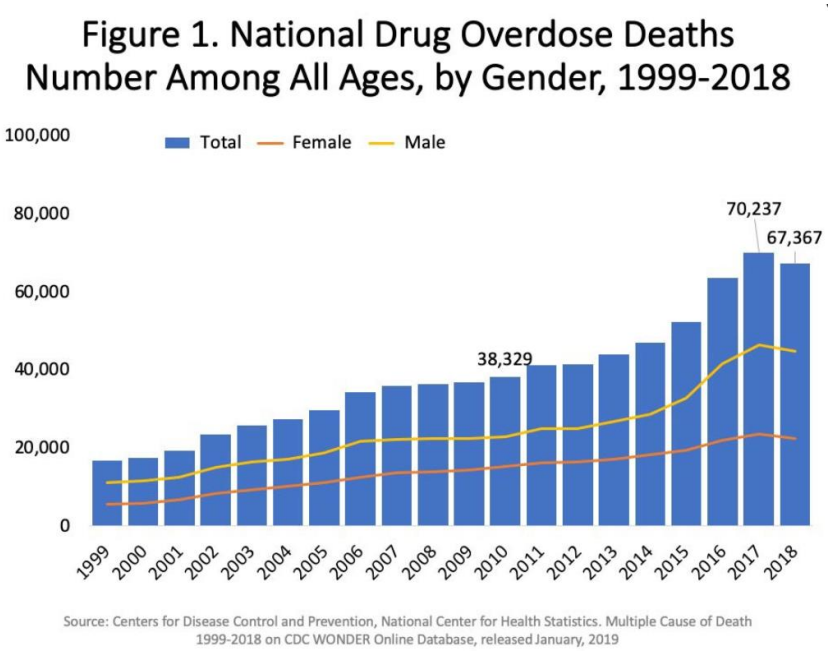
changing only the stories and not the first ten chapters (21) since, according to Anthony E., NAWS executive director, *"the Basic Text is still our primary source of revenue, and that literature sales still account for 90 percent of NAWS' income"* (51 pg 23-24).

NAWS requested new literature funding be spent on another edition of the Basic Text in English. Many addicts found this troublesome since the NA Fellowship is currently spoken in eighty-seven different languages. Yet the Basic Text is currently translated in only twenty-seven languages (77). Unfortunately, the funds were not used to reach addicts still suffering in other languages. Instead, NAWS moved forward with edition six of the basic text in English. (78).

The fellowship was asked what stories should be added to the basic text. However, the fellowship did not have any input or vote on what stories were removed from the basic text. *PotHead!* was removed from the stories in the sixth edition. There are addicts in NA who are/were addicted to Marijuana, and the whole Medical Marijuana topic is confusing to them when NAWS offers a blurred message. Having a story specifically addressing addicts whose drug of choice is marijuana was a critical component of the basic text. Marijuana is a mind altering, mood changing substance, legally prescribed or not. This move by NAWS seems to suggest that the sale of the Medical Marijuana industry, treatment friendly, Hazelton approved, Basic Text reaching the widest audience of potential book sales is what is most important. While sacrificing the therapeutic value of one addict helping another addict through written text. The updated version is the Basic Text 6th Edition (52).

Some addicts are concerned that the Basic Text 7th Edition will contain stories on " fake recovery" that include Drug Replacement Therapy (DRT), Medical Assisted Treatment (MAT), Medical Marijuana, and the removal of *complete absence* from the NA literature (65) resulting in even more book sales. Unfortunately, based on empirical historical data, continued watering down of the original NA addict-to-addict message will continue to move the Fellowship in the direction of continued fragmentation of the fellowship, a reduction in the number meetings, and a continued increase in the number of addicts dying (70).

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The foundation for such a notion is clearly presented in the World Services approved pamphlet *Narcotics Anonymous and Persons Receiving Medical Assisted Treatment* (56).

A few years after the completion of the sixth edition basic text, NAWS authored an essay titled *Narcotics Anonymous Copy Rights and Literature* which implied that the only approved version of the Basic Text in English is the sixth edition (11). This essay is used by NAWS to justify the removal of NA meetings from the na.org World Services meeting finder/directory (75). What is implied by World Service is that all other editions of the Basic Text are not NA approved literature. From a marketing perspective, it's a brilliant idea to force the sale of more books (21). From a traditions perspective, and the ability to reach the still suffering addict seeking recovery seems to be lost as NA's primary purpose. Per the NA Traditions, an NA Home Group can use whatever version of the Basic Text it wants to use in their meeting. Any Home Group can have a literature study, per the traditions, and may use whatever NA related material the group wants. As a matter of fact, as long as an NA Home Group follows the twelve steps and twelve traditions, the Home Group may do whatever it wants as long as it doesn't impact NA as a whole. Examples of impacting NA as a whole include; using another fellowships' literature, or having another fellowships' member come in as a speaker giving another fellowships' message.

In conclusion, it would appear the Grey Book, first edition through the third edition revised, and the Baby Blue are the only Basic Text's which were developed by addicts for addicts as a *Labor of Love* and

are Fellowship Approved via the Home Groups of Narcotics Anonymous. The fourth edition through sixth were heavily influenced by the treatment industry via the Hazelton Foundation with the consistent watering down of the addict to addict message creating more of a professional to addict tone, edited by paid professional for hire writers responsible to their employer (55) (57). The data also suggests that the World Service Office which was created as a service body responsible to the Fellowship as their book publishing company, holder of the copyright trust for the fellowship, and seller of some NA merchandise has morphed into a corporate structure effectively taking over the direction and decisions made for NA, thereby removing the responsible from the Home Groups, members of Narcotics Anonymous, and in violation of NA Traditions 2, 4, 7, and 9. This transformation has moved the World Service Office/NAWS oversight away from the Traditions and the Home Groups to a For Profit organization masquerading as a Non-Profit whose main object is no longer to serve the Fellowship and the sick and suffering addict, but is to increase the corporation's financial bottom line via book sales wherever possible with current administrative fees in excess of ninety-one percent; thereby less than 9 percent of the monies received going back to directly support the Fellowship (76).

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